Hence, Willy was at home, taking it out on the partridges. I'd have stayed with him, if I could, but I wasn't old enough to assert myself like that.

In Willy's absence, Pa and I had to face the Wall ourselves, which made it that much more unpleasant. I stuck close to Pa's side while the cameras whirred and clicked. Memories of the Spice Girls. Memories of Mummy, who also despised Klosters.

This is why she's hiding, I thought. This right here. This shit.

Mummy had other reasons besides the Wall for hating Klosters. When I was three, Pa and a friend were involved in a gruesome accident on the slopes there. A massive avalanche overtook them. Pa narrowly escaped, but the friend didn't. Buried under that wall of snow, the friend's final breaths must have been snow-filled gasps. Mummy often spoke of him with tears in her eyes.

After the Wall, I tried to put my mind to having fun. I loved skiing and I was good at it. But once Mummy was in my thoughts, I was buried under my own private avalanche of emotions. And questions. *Is it wrong to enjoy a place that Mummy despises? Am I being mean to her if I have fun today on these slopes? Am I a bad son for feeling excited to get on the chairlift alone with Pa? Will Mummy understand that I miss her and Willy but also enjoy having Pa briefly to myself?*

How would I explain any of this to her when she returned?

Some time after that trip to Klosters I shared my theory with Willy, about Mummy being in hiding. He admitted that he'd once entertained a similar theory. But, ultimately, he'd discarded it.

She's gone, Harold. She's not coming back.

No, no, no, I wouldn't hear such a thing. *Willy, she always said she wanted to just disappear! You heard her!*

Yes, she did. But, Harold, she'd never do this to us!

I'd had the very same thought, I told him. *But she wouldn't die either, Willy! She'd never do that to us either!*

Fair point, Harold.

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